

The Open Boat

Stephen Crane · 1897

First published: Scribner's, Jun 1897

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

AP edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Whole-book test and answer key
6. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Open_Boat (revision 13921851), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 10–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Open Boat suggest about nature's indifference?
- What does The Open Boat suggest about brotherhood?
- What does The Open Boat suggest about survival?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: AP

AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN

AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the

app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Open Boat	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*nature's indifference* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Open Boat

Author biography

Stephen Crane was born in Newark, New Jersey, on 1 November 1871, the fourteenth child of a Methodist minister. He worked as a journalist in New York and wrote The Red Badge of Courage (1895), a Civil War story, without having seen war. As a correspondent he survived the sinking of the steamer Commodore off Florida in January 1897, spending some thirty hours in a dinghy, the basis of "The Open Boat." He reported on the Greco-Turkish and Spanish-American wars and died of tuberculosis in Germany on 5 June 1900, aged 28.

Historical and cultural context

On 2 January 1897 the steamer SS Commodore, carrying arms to Cuban rebels fighting Spain, sank off Florida. Crane, aboard as a correspondent, spent about thirty hours in a ten-foot dinghy with the captain, the cook and an oiler, Billie Higgins, who drowned in the surf. The story is based on that ordeal.

Publication and reception, then and now

Published in Scribner's Magazine in June 1897, subtitled "A Tale Intended to be after the Fact. Being the Experience of Four Men from the Sunk Steamer Commodore."

Then: Admired by writers including Joseph Conrad and H. G. Wells.

Now: A central work of American naturalism and one of the great sea stories.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Four men (the captain, the cook, the oiler and the correspondent) row a small boat through heavy seas toward the Florida coast after their ship sinks.

Main themes

- nature's indifference.
- brotherhood.
- human fragility.

Why it matters

It shows a universe that doesn't care, and how people find meaning in solidarity.

Spoilers · teacher only

When they finally swim for shore, the strongest, the oiler, drowns; the others survive and feel they can now be "interpreters" of the sea.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open The Open Boat: When have you worked with others to survive a hard situation?
Prompt: Before we open The Open Boat: When have you worked with others to survive a hard situation?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

naturalism; irony; point of view; imagery.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. Stephen Crane was born in Newark, New Jersey, on 1 November 1871, the fourteenth child of a Methodist minister. He worked as a journalist in New York and wrote The Red Badge of Courage (1895), a Civil War story, without having seen war. As a correspondent he survived the sinking of the steamer Commodore off Florida in January 1897, spending some thirty hours in a dinghy, the basis of "The Open Boat." He reported on the Greco-Turkish and Spanish-American wars and died of tuberculosis in Germany on 5 June 1900, aged 28. The world of the book. On 2 January 1897 the steamer SS Commodore, carrying arms to Cuban rebels fighting Spain, sank off Florida. Crane, aboard as a correspondent, spent about thirty hours in a ten-foot dinghy with the captain, the cook and an oiler, Billie Higgins, who drowned in the surf. The story is based on that ordeal. Publication and reception. Published in Scribner's Magazine in June 1897, subtitled "A Tale Intended to be after the Fact. Being the Experience of Four Men from the Sunk Steamer Commodore." Then: Admired by writers including Joseph Conrad and H. G. Wells. Now: A central work of American naturalism and one of the great sea stories.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

"NONE of them knew the color of the sky" (The Open Boat, paragraph 1). The opening.

> *NONE of them knew the color of the sky (The Open Boat, paragraph 1)*

Think-aloud: "NONE of them knew the color of the sky" (The Open Boat, paragraph 1). The opening.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): Four men (the captain, the cook, the oiler and the correspondent) row a small boat through heavy seas toward the Florida coast after their ship sinks. Themes to track: nature's indifference.: brotherhood.: human fragility.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Open Boat: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does The Open Boat still matter? It shows a universe that doesn't care, and how people find meaning in solidarity.
Anchor question: Why might The Open Boat still be taught today?
Facilitation: It shows a universe that doesn't care, and how people find meaning in solidarity.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Why does the oiler's death matter? Answer: It shows nature does not reward strength or virtue.
Exit ticket: Why does the oiler's death matter?
Answer: It shows nature does not reward strength or virtue.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: The Open Boat.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "Stephen Crane" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Stephen-Crane); Stephen Crane Society (https://www.stephencranesociety.org/); Stephen Crane Society (https://www.stephencranesociety.org/); Crane's newspaper report "Stephen Crane's Own Story" (New York Press, 7 January 1897)

Lesson 2: The Open Boat

Focus: brotherhood against an indifferent sea

Content note (drowning): Sensitive content: Drowning. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes drowning.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

After a steamer sinks, four men, the injured captain, the cook, the oiler Billie and the correspondent, row a ten-foot dinghy for thirty hours off the Florida coast. They see land and a lifesaving station, but no one comes. Taking turns at the oars, they form a quiet brotherhood. At last they run the surf; the oiler, the strongest, drowns. The survivors feel they can now be 'interpreters' of the sea's voice.

Background: Crane survived the sinking of the Commodore on 2 January 1897 off Florida; the story appeared in Scribner's that June, subtitled 'A Tale Intended to be after the Fact.'

Significance: A classic of American naturalism: nature is neither cruel nor kind, only indifferent.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How do people change when they must depend on each other to survive? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to nature's indifference because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes drowning.
Prompt: How do people change when they must depend on each other to survive?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to nature's indifference because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: nature is "flatly indifferent."

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: transpired — became known; paddling — propel with a paddle; oarsman — someone who rows a boat; epithets — a defamatory or abusive word or phrase; unconcern — lack of worry or interest.
Words: transpired: became known · paddling: propel with a paddle · oarsman: someone who rows a boat · epithets: a defamatory or abusive word or phrase · unconcern: lack of worry or interest

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Crane survived the sinking of the Commodore on 2 January 1897 off Florida; the story appeared in Scribner's that June, subtitled 'A Tale Intended to be after the Fact.' A classic of American naturalism: nature is neither cruel nor kind, only indifferent. Point of view: Moves among the men, settling on the correspondent's mind. Imagery: Waves described as walls and "slate" threaten constantly. Irony: The strongest man dies. Watch for the boat: the shared human condition.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "NONE of them knew the color of the sky" (The Open Boat, paragraph 1). Focus on survival. That is point of view at work: Moves among the men, settling on the correspondent's mind.

> *NONE of them knew the color of the sky* *(The Open Boat, paragraph 1)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "NONE of them knew the color of the sky" (The Open Boat, paragraph 1). Focus on survival. That is point of view at work: Moves among the men, settling on the correspondent's mind.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Theme. Look at the craft: Waves described as walls and "slate" threaten constantly. Ask: How does this line connect to nature's indifference? Expected: Nature is "flatly indifferent." (Theme.)

> *But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent* *(The Open Boat, paragraph 207)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Theme. Look at the craft: Waves described as walls and "slate" threaten constantly.
Ask: How does this line connect to nature's indifference?
Expected answer: Nature is "flatly indifferent." (Theme.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for point of view, imagery (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about brotherhood against an indifferent sea? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Open Boat develops the idea of brotherhood against an indifferent sea. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. When the text says "But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent" (The Open Boat, paragraph 207), it shows this directly. The correspondent sees nature as "flatly indifferent," and the oiler dies anyway, but the survivors "felt that they could then be interpreters."
Task: Annotate the story for point of view, imagery (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about brotherhood against an indifferent sea? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Open Boat develops the idea of brotherhood against an indifferent sea. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. When the text says "But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent" (The Open Boat, paragraph 207), it shows this directly. The correspondent sees nature as "flatly indifferent," and the oiler dies anyway, but the survivors "felt that they could then be interpreters."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: How do people change when they must depend on each other to survive? Ask: what does the brotherhood in the boat mean?
Anchor question: How do people change when they must depend on each other to survive?
Facilitation: Ask: what does the brotherhood in the boat mean?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about brotherhood against an indifferent sea? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. ("But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent", The Open Boat, paragraph 207). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about brotherhood against an indifferent sea? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. ("But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent", The Open Boat, paragraph 207). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how point of view shapes brotherhood against an indifferent sea. Key takeaway: nature is "flatly indifferent."*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Point of view:** Moves among the men, settling on the correspondent's mind.
- **Imagery:** Waves described as walls and "slate" threaten constantly.
- **Irony:** The strongest man dies.

Themes and how they develop

- **nature's indifference:** nature is "flatly indifferent."

Symbols and motifs

- **the boat:** the shared human condition.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “NONE of them knew the color of the sky” (The Open Boat, paragraph 1) Focus on survival.
- “But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent” (The Open Boat, paragraph 207) Theme.
- “they felt that they could then be interpreters” (The Open Boat, paragraph 243) The ending.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other.
Evidence: “But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent” (The Open Boat, paragraph 207)
Reasoning: The correspondent sees nature as "flatly indifferent," and the oiler dies anyway, but the survivors "felt that they could then be interpreters."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
transpired (verb)	became known	*The correspondent did not know all that transpired afterward.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
paddling (verb)	propel with a paddle	*"All right, sir!" The cook turned on his back, and, paddling with an oar, went ahead as if he were a canoe.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

oarsman (noun)	someone who rows a boat	*Whereupon the little boat turned her nose once more down the wind, and all but the oarsman watched the shore grow.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
epithets (noun)	a defamatory or abusive word or phrase	*Four scowling men sat in the dingey and surpassed records in the invention of epithets.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
unconcern (noun)	lack of worry or interest	*It is, perhaps, plausible that a man in this situation, impressed with the unconcern of the universe, should see the innumerable flaws of his life and have them taste wickedly in his mind and wish for another chance.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
bequeathed (verb)	leave or give by will after one's death	*Neither knew they had bequeathed to the cook the company of another shark, or perhaps the same shark.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
carpets (noun)	floor covering consisting of a piece of thick heavy fabric (usually with nap or pile)	*Sometimes they sat down on the sea, near patches of brown sea-weed that rolled over the waves with a movement like carpets on line in a gale.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
overpowering (adjective)	very strong; impossible to resist	*The oiler plied the oars until his head drooped forward, and the overpowering sleep blinded him.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
dejection (noun)	a state of melancholy depression	*The injured captain, lying in the bow, was at this time buried in that profound dejection and indifference which comes, temporarily at least, to even the bravest and most enduring when, willy nilly, the firm fails, the army loses, the ship goes down.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
conference (noun)	a private talk	*A conference was held in the boat. "Well," said the captain, "if no help is coming, we might better try a run through the surf right away.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. How do people change when they must depend on each other to survive?
2. Where does point of view appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with nature's indifference?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How many men are in the dinghy? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: Four
2. Who is injured? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: The captain
3. What do the men see on shore that raises false hope? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: A man waving and a bus or omnibus
4. Who drowns in the surf? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: The oiler, Billie
5. What does the ending suggest the survivors can now be? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: Interpreters of the sea
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Open Boat” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: After a steamer sinks, four men, the injured captain, the cook, the oiler Billie and the correspondent, row a ten-foot dinghy for thirty hours off the Florida coast. They see land and a lifesaving station, but no one comes. Taking turns at the oars, they form a quiet brotherhood. At last they run the surf; the oiler, the strongest, drowns. The survivors feel they can now be 'interpreters' of the…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Open Boat”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Open Boat” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “The correspondent did not know all that transpired afterward.” What does “transpired” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: transpired: became known.
10. Reread: “"All right, sir!" The cook turned on his back, and, paddling with an oar, went ahead as if he were a canoe.” What does “paddling” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: paddling: propel with a paddle.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Open Boat” suggest about brotherhood against an indifferent sea? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A classic of American naturalism: nature is neither cruel nor kind, only indifferent.
2. Find one example of point of view in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.
3. How does the imagery in this story shape what we understand about brotherhood against an indifferent sea? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “NONE of them knew the color of the sky” (The Open Boat, paragraph 1): Focus on survival. On imagery: Waves described as walls and "slate" threaten constantly. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. In the passage that begins “The injured captain, lying in the bow, was at this time buried in that profound dejection and indifference which comes, temporarily at least, to even the bravest and most enduring…”, why might Crane have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Open Boat”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: After a steamer sinks, four men, the injured captain, the cook, the oiler Billie and the correspondent, row a ten-foot dinghy for thirty hours off the Florida coast. They see land and a lifesaving station, but no one comes. Taking turns at the oars, they form a quiet brotherhood. At last they run…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Open Boat” set up that the rest of The Open Boat will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent” (The Open Boat, paragraph 207): Theme. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “they felt that they could then be interpreters” (The Open Boat, paragraph 243): The ending. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “How do people change when they must depend on each other to survive?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does theme appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with nature's indifference? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: Look for statements or moments that connect to the book's big ideas.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “NONE of them knew the color of the sky” (The Open Boat, paragraph 1): Focus on survival. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Crane survived the sinking of the Commodore on 2 January 1897 off Florida; the story appeared in Scribner's that June, subtitled 'A Tale Intended to be after the Fact.' How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent” (The Open Boat, paragraph 207): Theme. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A classic of American naturalism: nature is neither cruel nor kind, only indifferent.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “they felt that they could then be interpreters” (The Open Boat, paragraph 243): The ending. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “NONE of them knew the color of the sky” (The Open Boat, paragraph 1): Focus on survival. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Open Boat” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about brotherhood against an indifferent sea? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent” (The Open Boat, paragraph 207): Theme. On point of view: Moves among the men, settling on the correspondent's mind. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Open Boat”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “they felt that they could then be interpreters” (The Open Boat, paragraph 243): The ending. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to brotherhood: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Crane need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “NONE of them knew the color of the sky” (The Open Boat, paragraph 1): Focus on survival. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Is the point of view in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent” (The Open Boat, paragraph 207): Theme. On point of view: Moves among the men, settling on the correspondent's mind. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Compare how “The Open Boat” treats brotherhood against an indifferent sea with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Open Boat see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “they felt that they could then be interpreters” (The Open Boat, paragraph 243): The ending. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve nature's indifference? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “NONE of them knew the color of the sky” (The Open Boat, paragraph 1): Focus on survival. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about brotherhood against an indifferent sea? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “But she was indifferent, flatly indifferent” (The Open Boat, paragraph 207): Theme. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Stephen Crane about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Crane shows nature is indifferent, leaving humans only each other. Useful evidence: “they felt that they could then be interpreters” (The Open Boat, paragraph 243): The ending. Theme link: nature is "flatly indifferent." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Point of view:** look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create
- Also notice **Theme**: statements or moments that connect to the book's big ideas

Chapter quiz

1. How many men are in the dinghy?
   A. Two
   B. Six
   C. Ten
   D. Four
2. Who is injured?
   A. The cook
   B. The correspondent
   C. The captain

D. The oiler

3. What do the men see on shore that raises false hope?
   A. A ship
   B. A lighthouse keeper rowing out
   C. A man waving and a bus or omnibus
   D. A fire
4. Who drowns in the surf?
   A. The correspondent
   B. The cook
   C. The oiler, Billie
   D. The captain
5. What does the ending suggest the survivors can now be?
   A. Sailors again
   B. Heroes
   C. Interpreters of the sea
   D. Rich men
6. In the line “The correspondent did not know all that transpired afterward.”, what does “transpired” most nearly mean?
   A. propel with a paddle
   B. someone who rows a boat
   C. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase
   D. became known
7. In the line “"All right, sir!" The cook turned on his back, and, paddling with an oar, went ahead as if he were a canoe.”, what does “paddling” most nearly mean?
   A. became known
   B. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase
   C. propel with a paddle
   D. someone who rows a boat

Answer key: 1. D (Four); 2. C (The captain); 3. C (A man waving and a bus or omnibus); 4. C (The oiler, Billie); 5. C (Interpreters of the sea); 6. D (became known); 7. C (propel with a paddle)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Open Boat,” how does Crane show brotherhood against an indifferent sea? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the point of view you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; AP: see unit standards): In The Open Boat, how does Crane develop the idea of brotherhood against an indifferent sea? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the point of view in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how The Open Boat develops the idea of brotherhood against an indifferent sea. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how the structure of The Open Boat (where it begins, turns and ends) and its point of view shape the reader's understanding of brotherhood against an indifferent sea. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Two readers disagree about what The Open Boat suggests about brotherhood against an indifferent sea. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's point of view and imagery), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Stephen Crane uses point of view in The Open Boat to complicate the reader's understanding of brotherhood against an indifferent sea. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Situate The Open Boat within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of brotherhood against an indifferent sea responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; AP: see unit standards): Read The Open Boat alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of brotherhood against an indifferent sea follows or bends those conventions, using the point of view as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; AP: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Open Boat and its treatment of brotherhood against an indifferent sea. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's point of view and imagery, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Open Boat as evidence for a larger claim about brotherhood against an indifferent sea in The Open Boat. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Open Boat as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of brotherhood against an indifferent sea. Position your reading

within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Open Boat.

SAT-style questions

1. *Whereupon the little boat turned her nose once more down the wind, and all but the oarsman watched the shore grow.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "oarsman" most nearly mean?

   A. a private talk

   B. very strong; impossible to resist

   C. a state of melancholy depression

   D. someone who rows a boat

2. *The injured captain, lying in the bow, was at this time buried in that profound dejection and indifference which comes, temporarily at least, to even the bravest and most enduring when, willy nilly, the firm fails, the army loses, the ship goes down. The mind of the master of a vessel is rooted deep in the timbers of her, though he command for a day or a decade, and this captain had on him the stern impression of a scene in the grays of dawn of seven turned faces, and later a stump of a top-mast with a white ball on it that slashed to and fro at the waves, went low and lower, and down. Thereafter there was something strange in his voice. Although steady, it was deep with mourning, and of a quality beyond oration or tears.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "The Open Boat"?

   A. Friendship tested by duty

   B. Accepting one's place in nature's cycle

   C. Brotherhood against an indifferent sea

   D. The arrogance and loneliness of seeing differently

SAT key: 1. D (someone who rows a boat); 2. C (Brotherhood against an indifferent sea)

Whole-book test

The Open Boat: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. How many men are in the dinghy?
   A. Two
   B. Six
   C. Ten
   D. Four
2. Who is injured?
   A. The cook
   B. The correspondent
   C. The captain
   D. The oiler
3. What do the men see on shore that raises false hope?
   A. A ship
   B. A lighthouse keeper rowing out
   C. A man waving and a bus or omnibus
   D. A fire
4. Who drowns in the surf?
   A. The correspondent
   B. The cook
   C. The oiler, Billie
   D. The captain
5. What does the ending suggest the survivors can now be?
   A. Sailors again
   B. Heroes
   C. Interpreters of the sea
   D. Rich men
6. In the line “The correspondent did not know all that transpired afterward.”, what does “transpired” most nearly mean?
   A. propel with a paddle
   B. someone who rows a boat
   C. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase
   D. became known

7. In the line “"All right, sir!" The cook turned on his back, and, paddling with an oar, went ahead as if he were a canoe.”, what does “paddling” most nearly mean?
   A. became known
   B. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase
   C. propel with a paddle
   D. someone who rows a boat
8. As used in the story (“The correspondent did not know all that transpired afterward.”), what does “transpired” mean?
   A. became known
   B. lack of worry or interest
   C. very strong; impossible to resist
   D. propel with a paddle
9. As used in the story (“"All right, sir!" The cook turned on his back, and, paddling with an oar, went ahead as if he were a canoe.”), what does “paddling” mean?
   A. leave or give by will after one's death
   B. propel with a paddle
   C. a state of melancholy depression
   D. someone who rows a boat
10. As used in the story (“Whereupon the little boat turned her nose once more down the wind, and all but the oarsman watched the shore grow.”), what does “oarsman” mean?
    A. floor covering consisting of a piece of thick heavy fabric (usually with nap or pile)
    B. a private talk
    C. someone who rows a boat
    D. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase
11. As used in the story (“Four scowling men sat in the dingey and surpassed records in the invention of epithets.”), what does “epithets” mean?
    A. very strong; impossible to resist
    B. became known
    C. lack of worry or interest
    D. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase
12. As used in the story (“It is, perhaps, plausible that a man in this situation, impressed with the unconcern of the universe, should see the innumerable flaws of hi”), what does “unconcern” mean?
    A. lack of worry or interest
    B. a state of melancholy depression
    C. propel with a paddle
    D. leave or give by will after one's death

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how nature's indifference develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how brotherhood develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how survival develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (nature's indifference, brotherhood, survival) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. D (Four); 2. C (The captain); 3. C (A man waving and a bus or omnibus); 4. C (The oiler, Billie); 5. C (Interpreters of the sea); 6. D (became known); 7. C (propel with a paddle); 8. A (became known); 9. B (propel with a paddle); 10. C (someone who rows a boat); 11. D (a defamatory or abusive word or phrase); 12. A (lack of worry or interest)

Essay assignments

Essay: Nature's indifference

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Open Boat teaches about nature's indifference. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Stephen Crane develops nature's indifference in The Open Boat. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Stephen Crane develops nature's indifference across The Open Boat. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Open Boat (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of nature's indifference. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of nature's indifference in The Open Boat. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Stephen Crane's choices in The Open Boat (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of nature's indifference, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Open Boat's treatment of nature's indifference in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on nature's indifference in The Open Boat that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on nature's indifference in The Open Boat. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about nature's indifference in The Open Boat, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on nature's indifference in The Open Boat, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Brotherhood

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Open Boat teaches about brotherhood. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Stephen Crane develops brotherhood in The Open Boat. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Stephen Crane develops brotherhood across The Open Boat. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Open Boat (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of brotherhood. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of brotherhood in The Open Boat. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Stephen Crane's choices in The Open Boat (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of brotherhood, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Open Boat's treatment of brotherhood in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on brotherhood in The Open Boat that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on brotherhood in The Open Boat. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about brotherhood in The Open Boat, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on brotherhood in The Open Boat, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Survival

Middle School (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Open Boat teaches about survival. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Stephen Crane develops survival in The Open Boat. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Stephen Crane develops survival across The Open Boat. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Open Boat (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of survival. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of survival in The Open Boat. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Stephen Crane's choices in The Open Boat (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of survival, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Open Boat's treatment of survival in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on survival in The Open Boat that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on survival in The Open Boat. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about survival in The Open Boat, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on survival in The Open Boat, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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